new stability in the North may well have provided a spur for the export of settlers and new ideas in the persons of Brahmin and Buddhist missionaries eager to challenge the superiority of the Jains who had gone before.

It was at this juncture that writing, and thus literacy, was first introduced, not just to the South but to most of India.

The Greeks who accompanied Alexander the Great on his epic rampage talked of the Indians as having no writing. However, the Achaemenid empire had been in political control of the Indus region since about 500 BCE onwards, and had introduced a written language based on a Persian Aramaic script known as Kharosthi. The wily counsellor Chanakya and his star pupil Chandragupta would surely have cut their teeth on this Kharosthi script in Persian-controlled Taxila. Chandragupta subsequently graduated to become one of many Indian mercenaries who initially fought for the Persians against Alexander, only to change sides and then change sides again to lead a revolt against Alexander's Greek successors in India. He went on to form an alliance with other Greeks and Indians which ended with his becoming sole ruler of much of Northern India.

But no empire can function without good communications. Chandragupta's extensive contacts, first with the Persians and then with Alexander and his exceptionally literate Macedonian officers, can only have impressed upon him the need for a local equivalent of the Kharosthi script. So, with Kharosthi and Greek as models, the Brahmi alphabet came into being, if not in the last years of Chandragupta's reign then very soon thereafter. When you compare the Kharosthi alphabet with Brahmi you can see obvious similarities, but Brahmi was a step up, thanks to the introduction of diacriticals to express more complex vowel sounds. So well thought out was this new alphabetical system that it went on to become the mother of all the Brahmic scripts of South and South-East Asia, including written Dravidian and its local variants.